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Teen And Up Audiences

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# The Edge of Strength

by NotMyDestiny

Summary

Creatures in the Whispering Woods are acting more and more strangely. Adora must confront her own struggles or risk losing everything.

# Chapter 1



It had been over a year since Adora had released the magic at the heart of Etheria, and the Whispering Woods were still full of wonder. The vegetation was lusher and more vibrant than ever. The animals were content and attuned to the magic flowing all around them. Birdsong wove through the air, accompanied by the soft rustling of animals going about their normal routines.

Adora, Catra, Glimmer, and Bow had entered the woods a few hours earlier to meet with a group of forest dwellers to ensure that their relations with neighboring communities would remain strong. Now, the Best Friend Squad was making the peaceful walk back toward Bright Moon Castle.

The afternoon moons were lowering in the sky, a clear sign that dusk would arrive within the hour. Adora wanted to be sure they'd be back at the castle before darkness could bring any additional dangers. She was the commander now of Bright Moon's guards, and so her thoughts were often on matters of safety and security. For now though, she resisted the urge to press for a faster pace and instead tried to listen to the casual chatter of her friends.

"That went even better than I expected," Bow exclaimed enthusiastically.

Catra smirked, "Of course it did. You show up with a smile and a few gadgets, and everyone loves you."

Glimmer replied, "Well, they should love us. We are working hard to build and maintain these relationships. And, we'll keep meeting for as long as it takes."

Adora smiled along, but her mind drifted. Her thoughts played back her own role at the meeting they had just left. She chewed the inside of her cheek as she ruminated on her own contributions. She worried that she might have said the wrong thing or come off as too awkward.

A prickling at the back of her neck pulled Adora from her analysis as she noticed that the woods had become eerily silent. She

strained her ears, but could not hear a single bird trill or animal noise now. She put out her arms to slow the group as she glanced warily out at the woods.

The sudden rushing sound of a large animal swiftly approaching cut through the silence. Without another thought, Adora called forth her magic, and with a burst of light, she transformed into She-Ra and brandished her sword just as an Etherian wolf appeared before them. It had pale green fur and three pearly blue eyes on each side. It seemed uncharacteristically agitated as it pawed at the ground.

It snarled aggressively, and Adora stepped forward to take the full attention of the creature. Adora could hear her friends going into defense mode behind her, the shing of Catra's claws coming out, the crackle of Glimmer's magic forming in her palms, and the sound of a bow being drawn. It was good that they were ready, but Adora was determined to protect everyone as She-Ra and face this wolf alone.

"Stay back. I've got this," Adora said, not waiting for any protests.

She called on her magic to try and connect with the wolf and subdue it, but the connection wouldn't form; the creature was too far gone. It snapped suddenly at her outstretched arm before she could react. Pain coursed through her, and Adora staggered for a moment.

"Adora!" Catra called out.

The wolf suddenly turned on its heel and sprinted back into the forest with an odd, distressed sound before any of them could react further. Adora immediately focused her healing power onto herself, and her bitten arm quickly began to heal. She could vaguely hear her friends approaching and reacting in the background, but her focus needed to remain on her magic until the wound was closed up and like new again.

She felt Catra reaching for her, even as she quickly looked up to reassure her. “I’m fine now. It’s healed. See?” Adora waved her arm, showing it was as good as new. Though a bit of pain did still linger she wasn’t about to admit that. She also felt a bit drained and uneasy, but she was determined to push through and not let them see.

Catra narrowed her eyes. “You can wave your arm around all you want, but that doesn’t just erase what happened.”

She would have said more, but Bow cut in first. “Yeah, that was too close, Adora. Next time, don’t rush in alone like that, okay?”

Adora nodded, not really wanting to say more. She was She-Ra, she needed to try in these types of situations, but she knew if she voiced this aloud, her friends would just say they should all work together, and they wouldn’t really understand why she still thought that way, still wanted to protect and control the situation herself.

Glimmer’s voice broke through, “Our animals don’t normally act like that. The way it suddenly just ran off again, too. That definitely wasn’t just normal aggression.”

Bow nodded, “At least it’s gone now, but I hate not knowing why it acted like that.”

Luckily, these comments turned their attention from Adora’s behavior back to the wolf, and they continued to discuss that as they emerged from the woods and approached Bright Moon castle. Adora’s thoughts, though, did still linger on whether trying to take the lead on her own had been the right decision after all. It sometimes seemed like there was no right answer, and no matter what she did, she was left uncertain.

As they neared the safety of the structure, Adora released her transformation, her sword and armor fading. They retired to their respective bedrooms. Melog greeted Catra and Adora as they entered, its form growing a bit as it sensed they were still a little

on edge. Then it flickered to a comforting blue and nudged against their palms softly. They both gave it gentle pats.

Catra said, "We ran into some trouble with a wolf on our way back."

Adora nodded, "But we handled it and we're fine now."

She quickly removed her jacket and boots and readied herself for sleep, not really wanting to see Catra's expression, knowing that it would likely be skeptical and maybe a bit judging. Adora curled up in bed, and after a bit, Catra lay beside her and draped an arm around Adora. Even if she hadn't liked how Adora had reacted, Adora knew Catra still wanted to keep her close after that scare. So, the two fell asleep together.

Adora dreamed, and the Whispering Woods returned, but shadowy and strange. She found herself facing off with the wolf once more. As she raised her sword, it instantly dissolved into mist. She tried to step back, but her legs trembled and buckled. The world tilted beneath her and faded away as she awoke drenched in a feverish sweat. Careful to control herself, Adora worked hard not to awaken Catra and to will herself to lie still until she somehow managed to fall back into a dreamless sleep.

In the morning, Catra awoke beside her and took in Adora's disheveled and sweat-stained appearance with concern. Catra touched her cheek, but it felt cool. Adora awoke at the touch and, seeing Catra's distressed look, quickly started to reassure her. "I'm okay. I think I just re-lived that attack from the wolf in my dream, and it was a bit intense."

Catra looked unconvinced, like she wanted to say more, but Adora quickly started getting ready for the day ahead. She had already dressed and pulled on her boots and was securing her jacket when Catra reached for her arm. "You sure you're okay?"

"Don't worry the big bad wolf isn't going to get me in my dreams. I'm tougher than that." Adora replied, trying to deflect with humor.

She gave Catra a quick kiss on the forehead without meeting her eyes and rushed out of their room before Catra could press further.

Adora called over her shoulder, “I’ve got to be ready for my meeting with the guards, but I’ll see you a bit later.” Adora hurried off down the hall, her thoughts already starting to churn with guilt over how she’d brushed off Catra’s well-meaning concern.

# Chapter 2

In the Bright Moon Council Chamber, Adora had gathered with General Juliet and the other senior guards for their morning briefing over pastries and tea. Light infused the room from the crystal fixture glowing high above, as they sat back in the large purple throne-like chairs and began their discussion.

Adora greeted the gathered guards with authority, “Good morning. I have some news about something unusual in the Whispering Woods yesterday evening. We encountered a wolf that acted very oddly. It was agitated and distressed, and it attacked.”

General Juliet took this in and replied, “Whatever drove that wolf to attack, it wasn’t hunger. The Woods have plenty of prey. We’ll need extra patrols near the village borders.”

Adora nodded, “Yes, double the watch at dusk and dawn. No one goes out alone until we know what we’re dealing with.”

Another guard asked, “Commander, you really think it’ll come back?”

Adora replied with steady reassurance, “If it does, it won’t catch us unprepared. We won't put the villagers at risk.”

They continued to discuss additional security measures and plans for patrol rotations and observation to assess if this was more than a one-off incident. As the meeting progressed, Adora began to feel the pressure of a headache forming behind her eyes.

At the conclusion of the briefing, Adora headed out to the training yard for a session with the junior guards. As commander, Adora certainly could have had someone else do this, but it was actually something she quite enjoyed. Today, she had planned an initial swordsmanship lesson and demonstration.

Before she had made it to the yard, colorful wings unfurled in her path.

“Hey, Swifty,” Adora greeted her favorite steed.

“Adora, are you okay? I sensed some distress through out connection last night.”

“It's okay, Swifty, there was a wolf attack, but everyone’s fine.”

Swift Wind seemed to calm at that, and she patted his nose affectionately, leaning in for a quick squeeze before adding, “I have to get going, though, Swifty, the junior squad is waiting for me.”

Swift Wind replied, “Of course, you can't keep your troops waiting. Hopefully, we can fly together again sometime soon.”

“We definitely will,” Adora assured him as she hurried onward.

Adora arrived at the training yard and completed her swordsmanship demonstration. As she finished the last move, an eager guard called out, “Whoa! How do you swing the sword like that without falling over?”

With a grin, Adora replied, “Years of practice… and a lot of falling over first.”

Another young guard said, “But you make it look so easy!”

“It’s not supposed to be easy, but with practice, you’ll find it's more than possible,” Adora said with assurance.

She gathered the group and they headed into the dining hall for a late lunch. Being with the enthusiastic young guards almost made her not notice the continued pressure in her temples. Between bites, the group chatted away.

One said to another, “You almost fell over your own spear today.”

She replied, “It was a tactical maneuver.”

“Yeah, you tactically face planted.”

Adora joined in with some encouragement, “Hey, falling happens. The important part is getting back up.”

One of the guards turned toward her with curiosity. “So… what’s the best part of being She-Ra?”

Adora chewed thoughtfully. “Honestly? When it’s over and I can take my boots off.”

The guards all laughed at that.

Another braved a question. “Do you ever lose a fight?”

Adora answered, “Only when Queen Glimmer argues about dessert.” She noticed her hand seemed to tremble a bit as she lifted her cup, but she brushed it off.

Anyway, it was time for her next briefing now. This time with Glimmer, Catra, and Bow. She excused herself and made her way back to the Council Chamber. As she entered the large room, she saw that the three were already present. She smiled at them as brightly as she could manage, given the unrelenting pounding still pulsing through her head.

She took in their returning grins as she slid into her typical chair. “How are you all doing? Had a good day so far?” Her tone was warm, though possibly more forced than she had intended.

Glimmer replied first, “Busy, but productive. I finally worked through a stack of petitions that’s been waiting for a week.”

Bow added, “Mine’s been pretty good. I even got Glimmer to sit still long enough to eat lunch together.”

Catra arched an eyebrow, “I was fine, but then you asked a suspiciously cheerful question, so now I’m worried.”

Adora waved her off, “Anyway, I do have updates from the guards. We are doubling up patrols and rotating night watches. We are preventing any villagers from entering the Woods for now.

The junior squads are holding their own, but I want them to have more training on formation discipline. I'll run another drill tomorrow."

"Good." Glimmer replied, "I want those measures in place immediately. If the Woods are unsettled, then so is our kingdom. We need all the guards, including the junior squad, on this and ready."

"I think the junior guards are going to feel really proud, knowing they're part of something this important." Bow added.

Catra nodded along, "I've had extra lanterns, ropes and cloaks delivered already. If they're moving through the Woods at night, I want them well protected."

Adora gave her an approving smile, her pride for the women she loved shining through. Catra really was the best at coordinating the logistics of the kingdom, and she had come so far over the past year, really atoning for her past actions and working on controlling her anger and contributing to the betterment of Etheria.

Bow sighed, "This feels like us at our best, working together like this."

Catra gave him a bit of side eye and said teasingly, "Don't get sappy now."

With that, they headed to the dining hall to eat some dinner together. They passed the platters of food around, enjoying some non-work time with one another. As Adora took the last platter, her hand shook unexpectedly, and she abruptly set it down, carefully trying not to draw any attention.

Luckily, they were all attuned to Bow as he updated them on the cool new feature he had just been adding to the tracker pads. Adora, however, was finding it hard to follow as the pressure in her head was building again. She closed her eyes for a moment, trying to push off the feeling.

When she blinked them open again, she felt Catra's sharp gaze assessing her. Adora forced a smile and just barely managed not to say she was fine, which she knew was a total tell. She swallowed down a few more bites of food, trying to keep up appearances despite how non-existent her appetite had become.

"I-I have another briefing with the General," she said abruptly as she rose to her feet and guiltily found herself repeating her morning retreat all over again.

As she headed toward Juliet's evening post, her shame at avoiding Catra again settled over her more fully. But as the General came into sight, Adora swallowed down her feelings, pushed aside the pounding throb in her head and squared her shoulders, projecting the confidence of the Commander she was.

"Do you have an update, General?" Adora prompted.

"Yes, Commander, there were sightings of a few more animals behaving erratically at the edges of the Whispering Woods. There was an account of a fox that ran straight into a tree and of birds banging themselves into windows. They all retreated quickly back into the Woods."

Blinking back the pounding behind her eyes, Adora replied in a steady tone, "Document every incident. We'll need to keep track of the details. Also, please make sure the patrols tonight are reinforced and that they keep to the borders of the Woods without entering."

Juliet nodded in agreement and went to ready the first night patrol.

Adora headed to her own office for the first time that day to write up her own report. The pounding at her temples persisted, and her thoughts filled with concern as to whether the plans for the guards were the best they could be or if there was something more or different that she should be doing. She was always good

at being decisive when needed, but she often found doubt creeping in later once she was alone with her thoughts.

She sank into the chair at her desk and, on her own for once, actually let herself rub a hand against her forehead to try and reduce a bit of the constant pounding. An odd sound of scratching, like claws trying to scrape out from within the walls around her, seemed to suddenly overtake the room. A heaviness settled around her shoulders, and the tiny hairs on the back of her neck stood on end as an overwhelming sense of being watched washed over her.

The door to her office creaked, and she whipped around, heart racing.

But it was just Bow, smiling and holding out a tracker pad. “Hey, Adora, I didn’t mean to startle you. Just wanted to drop off the tracker pad I was mentioning at dinner.”

“Right. No problem. Thanks,” Adora stammered, trying to quickly regain control of herself. She almost wanted to ask him if he’d heard the scratching, but she realized it must have been in her own head. Probably just her overstimulated brain reliving that encounter with the wolf again.

“Have a good night, Bow.” Adora managed to say calmly.

“You too, Adora. Make sure you get some sleep soon, alright?” Bow responded.

“Yeah, I will,” she agreed with a nod and a tight smile as he left.

Adora turned back to her desk and scrawled out the bare minimum needed for her report, not wanting to spend another minute than she had to in this office right now. She rose and quickly made her way back to her room, her thoughts purely on escape.

As she entered, she saw Melog and Catra, both of whom should have meant comfort, but at the moment only made her feel

trapped. A wave of guilt filled her as she willed herself to calm down and return to herself once more.

Catra gave her a look of concern as she approached. “Something’s been off with you all day.” She reached to thread her fingers with Adora’s, and Adora let her.

“You know me too well. But right now I’d rather just… stay close to you than talk.”

Catra nodded, stroking some stray hairs back from her face, seeming to relent.

Adora changed into her sleep clothes and curled up close next to Catra. She took in deep breaths, trying to will herself closer to sleep, but she couldn't seem to escape her own swirling thoughts.

What was happening to her? She was the Commander of the guards and She-Ra. She couldn't afford to unravel. Not now, not when there was something afoot in the Whispering Woods. What kind of commander was she? So unsure now if she was leading the guards astray. Not sure if she truly knew how to be She-Ra, protector of Etheria, when her hands trembled and her attention was drifting. Each thought led into the next, and the guilt was growing like a bottomless pit. Adora stared up at the ceiling, feeling like she was losing control.

# Chapter 3

Adora eventually managed to get a few hours of sleep, but woke early, her thoughts still swirling. She quietly dressed and slipped from the room without waking Catra or Melog. She paused at the door for a moment and looked longingly at Catra, curled up asleep. She really wanted to just crawl back into bed with her, but she couldn't face the conversation that would come upon waking. So, she turned and left, guilt and shame flaring within her. She felt her head begin to pound, and her hands started to tremble. She speed walked down the hall.

She arrived quite early at the Council Chamber, her thoughts still spiraling. She sank into her chair and clenched her trembling hands but it didn't still their tremors. She raised one to the base of her skull and tried to press away the pain building there, but it offered little relief. Maybe if she used her magic, she could heal herself and fix this.

She concentrated and focused on pulling the magic from within her. It rose up, but felt almost a bit distant. It also didn’t seem to touch the pulsing pain in her head or the desperate shaking of her hands. The failure left her more anxious than ever. Why couldn't she just fix this?

The eery sound of a low whisper seemed to echo around her. “You’ll hurt them all.” The words were in her own voice, though she certainly hadn’t spoken. Adora’s gaze darted around the room frantically, and the glow from the crystal light fixture above her seemed to flicker in and out for a moment.

The sound of approaching footsteps forced her to attention. She took deep breaths and worked to quickly pull herself together. She tucked her hands into her lap to hide their tremors.

The door to the chamber opened softly, and General Juliet and the senior guards filed into the room and took their seats.

In a controlled tone, Adora greeted them, “Good morning, everyone. General, do you have a report on last night’s patrols?” Her heart was still pounding, but she had managed not to show it.

General Juliet replied, “The patrols all came back safely last night, which is good. There were some additional unusual animal sightings at the edges of the Woods. An owl flew low and erratic, and a fox was spotted dazedly circling and hissing.”

Adora took that in and replied, “We need to make it the utmost priority to capture one of these creatures for further investigation. These aren’t isolated incidents. We need to…we should…”

Adora’s voice trailed off as her mind felt suddenly foggy and distant, like she couldn't quite access her own thoughts. She could feel the stares of the guards waiting for her to continue, but she couldn't seem to refocus.

Juliet cut in smoothly, “What the Commander is getting at is that these aren’t random incidents, and so we need to find a cause.”

Shame and relief flooded through Adora in equal measure at this smooth cover. The other guards, hopefully, hadn't even noticed that she had faltered.

Adora dismissed all the guards, avoiding eye contact with Juliet, and pulling aside her senior lieutenant. Turning toward the woman, she said, “I need you to run the formation drill with the junior squad today.” Adora had been planning to conduct the upcoming training herself, but at this point, given her state, it seemed prudent to delegate it.

Adora instead decided to go check on the patrol at the edge of the woods and see how preparations for capturing an animal were coming.

As she headed over, her thoughts remained on that last lapse of focus. If she couldn't even keep her thoughts straight, how was she supposed to command troops and protect Etheria? Another tremor shook through her hands, and the pain in her head

throbbed in rhythm. She really needed to get a hold of herself. She stood still for a moment, steadying herself before she approached the edge of the Woods.

Three mid-level guards paced the border of the Woods in formation. They had nets and stun batons at the ready.

"Any sightings?" Adora asked as she approached.

"It's been quiet since we started our shift, but the fox was spotted near here this morning," the most senior guard reported.

Adora paced and surveyed the border herself, focusing intently on what she could see in the Woods and managing to keep all other thoughts at bay.

"There's movement by the undergrowth over here," the furthest guard called out.

Adora headed carefully forward as they spotted a fox, its eyes unfocused and its movements erratic. "Stay sharp and have your nets ready," she commanded calmly as the team approached skillfully in a well-practiced maneuver.

A sudden wave of anger flooded through Adora seemingly out of nowhere, and she found herself shouting abruptly, "Closer formation! Don't leave gaps! This isn't a game!"

The guards startled at the unexpected tone, and Adora, eyes darting, faltered, "I-I'm sorry. You're doing fine. I'm just…" She exhaled slowly, willing herself to calm down. "Just take it slow and steady."

The guards approached carefully and secured the fox within a net before touching a stun baton to its side. It stilled with the pulse of electrical energy.

Adora said softly, "Well done. Mission accomplished." She felt her hands trembling, and she clenched them into fists at her sides. As Adora headed away toward the castle, she watched as the guards

carefully wrapped the unconscious fox and prepared it for secure transport.

She wondered what had happened back there. It was like something suddenly overcame her control, a surge of anger like she had rarely felt before. As her thoughts churned, the pounding in her head worsened. She walked past the Dining Hall, but she knew she couldn't stomach eating right now, so she continued on, heading back to the Council Chamber.

Once again, she was the first to arrive, and she sank into her chair, willing herself to regain some sense of normalcy. She needed to stabilize herself before her friends arrived. She took in slow, deep breaths and willed herself to calm down as much as possible.

Catra entered, and Adora smiled over at her nervously and said softly, "Hi."

Catra's gaze was layered with frustration and concern, sweeping carefully over Adora as if assessing her state as she approached and sat nearby her. But her tone was all gentle care. "Adora, you slipped out so early this morning. How are you?"

Before Adora had decided how honest an answer she should give, Glimmer and Bow entered laughing together.

Glimmer greeted them brightly as she slid into her chair, "Hey, Catra! Hey Adora! Bow and I just had the best cake at lunch. Did you have any?"

"I must have missed it," Adora mumbled and then brightening a bit, "It's good to see you both."

Luckily, Bow chimed in as he sat across from her, "Next time, I'm smuggling some extra for you. No commander of the guard should miss out on dessert."

Adora smiled, though she was sure it didn't quite meet her eyes, and said, "Thanks, Bow, you're the best. I've had a pretty busy

morning, actually. We caught a fox near the Woods that was acting oddly. Maybe it can give us some answers."

Bow nodded, "I'll run some scans and see what I can find out."

Glimmer said with crisp determination, "We'll get magical readings as well. We need to know more about why this is spreading through the animals."

Adora nodded, "I'm going to go back into the Woods as She-Ra and see if I can find any signs there."

"What? Adora!" Catra's voice rang out sharply. "I'm not letting you do that alone."

"Okay, come with me then," Adora replied, knowing that this was likely the only way she'd be able to go. She saw Catra's eyes widen in surprise at the invite before she quickly nodded her assent.

Adora rose, and Catra followed her out into the hall. "I… I just need to see for myself if there is anything more that could help us figure this out. I don't want to risk the guards in the Woods. I can handle this as She-Ra." Her confidence strengthened as she spoke.

Catra placed a gentle hand on her shoulder, "I know you can, but that doesn't mean you should be alone."

Adora nodded, and they stepped out of the castle and headed towards the Woods. As they approached, Adora paused to call forth her magic. As she always did, she focused on pulling from deep within herself, but this time, something felt like it was jammed, like something was stopping her from accessing her magic. She focused a bit more, but suddenly her vision began to blur at the edges, and she felt a buzzing in her ears.

Catra's hands were gripping her shoulders, "Adora, are you okay? You've gone very pale."

Catra's voice sounded oddly far away. Adora blinked rapidly, trying to push the dizzy sensation away. Her knees buckled, but she managed to stay upright, and then slowly her vision began to clear.

One of Catra's arms was looped around her waist now, and her words came a bit clearer this time. "Adora, what's happening? You're shaking."

"I.. I'm okay," Adora stuttered out weakly as she tried to regain her balance. "I.. I don't think I can transform."

"This is not okay, Adora."

"I didn't eat any lunch. I barely slept. I think I'm just exhausted," Adora admitted softly.

"Adora, you need to take better care of yourself. Come on, let's get you back to our room so you can rest."

Adora leaned a bit into Catra, still not feeling fully stable on her feet as they walked back into the castle. Embarrassment and shame filled her, and she found herself trembling again, the pounding in her head returning with rapid intensity.

"Adora, are you okay now?"

"I've been feeling a little shaky all day, actually, and I've had this recurring headache since yesterday."

"Okay, that's okay. We'll figure this out." Adora could hear the fear mounting in Catra's voice even as she tried to say stabilizing words.

"I really think I just need to sleep a bit more. I'll be okay then."

They reached their room, and Catra guided Adora onto the bed, and she let herself lean back against the pillows and close her eyes. Catra tugged off her boots and then curled up next to her and stroked stray hairs back from her face.

Adora wanted to just give in and confess everything to Catra. To tell her about the weird sensations she’d noticed, the scratching and the eerie voice she’d heard, the way her mind had wandered and how she’d gotten suddenly angry. But she found she couldn’t. She was afraid that she’d make Catra too concerned or that her neediness might push her away. As her fears mounted, Adora felt her hands trembling under the blanket and the pulsing in her temples increasing, but she didn't say anything more. She lay still and pretended like she was just trying to rest.

# Chapter 4

Eventually, her exhaustion outweighed her distress, and Adora drifted off as the soft glow of afternoon light wafted across their bedroom floor. Her head rested comfortably against Catra's shoulder, and her breathing relaxed into the steady rhythm of sleep.

A bit later, she felt the press of Catra's cheek against her forehead as she stirred awake and blinked open her eyes, taking in the pinkish glow of dusk. She slowly disentangled herself from Catra, who stirred as well at her movements.

"Adora?" the soft, raspy voice questioned, and then, as memory returned from the vestiges of sleep, "How are you feeling?"

Adora took a moment to fully take stock of herself. She found that she actually felt better than she had in a while. Her earlier headache and tremors had faded for once. "Better, actually," she replied with surprise and relief. She slowly pushed up into a sitting position as if testing the waters, but found no symptoms returned. Her stomach rumbled, and Adora realized she was hungry again after not having eaten all day. "I'm starving."

"There should still be some dinner left at the dining hall if we head right over," Catra replied, relief clear in her tone.

They both slid off the bed, and Adora pulled her boots back on and restyled her hair into its familiar poof and ponytail. As she readied herself, she gave Melog a few soft pats as it curled gently around her legs.

The two headed out of the room and over to the dining hall. Adora could feel Catra's gaze upon her as if looking for any signs of returning weakness. It flooded her with a feeling of guilt and then the burn of shame at being a burden. As if the thoughts had summoned it, she felt a sudden pressure building again behind her eyes, and she tried not to let it show.

Luckily, they had arrived at the dining hall and saw Bow and Glimmer still finishing up. They slid down beside them and exchanged pleasant greetings. Adora quickly filled her plate with food, hoping that eating something would help her feel better again.

"We have some updates on the fox," Bow began. "It definitely had some odd readings. It has some weird First Ones tech like signals coming from it and a significantly reduced magical signature from what we'd usually expect as well."

Adora had quickly eaten most of her plateful of food, but she frowned now at that news. "That does sound odd."

Glimmer asked, "Did you two find anything else in the Woods?"

Adora felt a pressure in her chest at that question as the memory of her failed transformation at the edge of the Woods filled her mind, along with a wave of disappointment and anxiety at her failure. Her eyes widened and then darted around frantically.

Catra jumped in, "We didn't actually make it to the Woods." Adora threw her an anxious look. How much was Catra going to say?

Adora could feel her heart and head pounding now in a tight rhythm. Her hands started to tremble, and she quickly shoved them into her lap before anyone could notice.

The light from the crystals above seemed to flicker in and out, shadows in the hall jumped around the floor, and she heard the low whisper of her own voice echoing in her ears, "You will always fail them all."

Her heart was in her throat now, and she jumped up suddenly. "I-I just need some air," Adora said quickly as she rushed toward the doors. She speed walked down the hall and outside and practically crashed right into Swift Wind.

"Adora? Are you okay? I sensed your distress a few hours ago, and it felt like your magic was fragmented. You also seem

distressed again now."

She had visibly startled at his presence and found herself trembling now. She wrapped her arms around herself tightly, willing herself to calm down. "I-I…" she tried to answer, but couldn't seem to get herself to continue, her body was in such a state of panic and confusion. Instead, she pressed her face into his neck and began to cry.

Swift Wind immediately stopped talking and tilted his head down to nuzzle her with his nose. He blew a small puff of gentle air out of his nostrils into her hair as a gesture of additional comfort.

Adora couldn't believe she had lost control like this. Why was she always so sensitive and emotional? She was letting every little thing affect her and drive her to tears. Nothing had even really happened. It was all just some stress response causing her mind to see these odd things. She knew that, and she really needed to just calm down. She clenched her fists at her side and took long breaths in through her nose, trying to regain control. The pain in her head pounding now more than ever.

She felt someone else approaching and lifted her head to check, and saw Catra hurrying over. "Adora, what is going on?" Her words were full of concern as she lifted a hand to Adora's cheek to cup it tenderly and stroke away her tears. "Talk to me, please."

Catra reached to take her hand, and Adora knew she could feel the tremor in it.

"I-I'm not sure really. I think I'm just letting the stress of this situation with the animals in the Woods get to me."

Catra nodded, "Okay, stress, I get that, but I've seen you under pressure a lot, and this feels different somehow."

Adora looked down at her feet and said softly, "Sometimes I feel like I have to be She-Ra or the Commander, and it's just an act, like a role I'm performing for everyone else, when really I don't know what to do. It's not really me."

Adora wasn't sure if she was explaining herself right or if this would make any sense to Catra or Swift Wind, but she wanted to try to convey her feelings as best as she could right now. She pressed a shaky hand to her temple and rubbed it in a slow circle.

Catra wrapped an arm around her, likely to help stabilize her in this moment as she said in a soft and sincere tone, "It's only Adora that matters to me. I've always loved you as just my Adora. You don't need to be anything else for me."

Swift Wind added, "You are allowed to be just you." Adora patted his neck.

She leaned her head onto Catra's shoulder and said softly, "Let's go back to our room now and get some sleep."

As they walked back inside and toward their room, Adora tried to keep herself grounded on Catra's loving support and comforting presence, but it just wasn't quite enough to keep her anxious thoughts at bay. Adora just knew that she was too weak and unstable to keep things under control. She was pressing all of her problems onto Catra and becoming such a burden, and she wasn't leading the guards or controlling the situation with the animals like she should.

Adora's hands shook, and her head pounded as they made their way into their room. Melog sensed her distress and came over to curl around her legs in comfort. Adora gave it an absent-minded pat as she tried to busy herself with getting ready for bed.

She splashed some water on her face and looked up at her reflection in the mirror, seeing her round, red-rimmed and tired blue eyes. Then the image before her distorted into a cruel and mocking version of her own visage. It peered at her with disappointment and disdain, her eyes flashing suddenly red.

Adora quickly pulled her gaze away and gripped the edges of the sink so tightly her knuckles went white as her heart raced in her

chest and the pounding in her head intensified. She willed herself to try and calm down. Was this all really just stress?

Somewhat getting a grip on herself, she turned toward the bed and lay down. Catra slid in beside her, draping an arm across Adora. “You okay? You feel tense.”

Adora sighed and tried to relax her taut muscles. “Sorry, it's just the stress. I’ll be better after I get some more sleep.”

Catra was silent again, and Adora could tell she wanted to say something more, but after a few more moments of silence, it seemed she had relented. Instead, she just rubbed her hand gently along Adora’s back and shoulders as she whispered, “Okay, get some sleep now.”

In the still of the night, with no one to see, a faint glowing symbol flickered briefly across Adora’s forehead. It was an array of lines and shapes, a piece of First Ones’ language. It disappeared as quickly as it had come. Its odd presence a sign that whatever this was, it was definitely something more than just stress.

# Chapter 5

Morning light streamed into the bedroom, and Adora stirred slowly awake. She blinked her eyes open and looked over at Catra, still curled beside her, chest rising and falling steadily in sleep. Adora watched with a small smile as, with eyes still closed, Catra unfurled in a stretch, her claws flexing and retracting without conscious thought, as she too began to awaken.

A wave of warmth and contentment washed through Adora as they awoke like this so peacefully together. Her gaze lingered on Catra, round blue eyes filled with affection. Catra blinked over at her and returned her smile.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said softly, raising a hand to stroke a few stray hairs back from her face. "This is a nice way to wake up." But then, Adora could see the change in her eyes as concern crept in, "How are you doing?"

"Better after sleeping for sure," Adora replied quickly, wanting to reassure her. Her eyes darted downward as she felt a wave of guilt creeping in as she remembered all of her recent behavior and the shame at recognizing that she was the one causing Catra to have so suddenly dropped her smile. If Adora could just hold things together better, they could be happy, but lately that seemed like an impossibility.

The light of the room suddenly felt too bright, and Adora blinked her eyes closed as a pounding began once more behind them. She felt a tremor start in her hands and run through her. Her whole body was trembling out of her control.

She could feel Catra stiffen beside her as she said softly, "Hey, you're shaking."

"I-I'm okay," Adora said even as she clenched her jaw and tried to will away the sensations.

Catra reached for her arm and stroked it gently, “This doesn’t look like okay. Maybe you should rest some more?”

Adora felt shame and annoyance rise within her in equal measures as she swiftly shook her head in opposition. “We need to go see Glimmer and Bow. We need to figure out what is going on with those animals.” Adora was pressing up from the bed even as she felt Catra reaching for her.

Adora began to quickly pull on her clothes and boots as she kept her eyes averted from Catra, and she felt guilt threatening to overwhelm her once more. She clenched her muscles as she futilely tried to control the ever-growing tremors and pounding in her head

“Adora, you’re worrying me.”

“I need to be doing something, Catra. I can’t just sit here.”

“You’re impossible,” Catra replied with a resigned sigh, but Adora could hear that she, too, was now moving about the room and getting ready.

Once they were both presentable, Adora reached for her hand and gave it a squeeze, and Catra squeezed back. Despite growing frustrations, they were still in this together.

Hands still entwined, they walked into the dining hall and quickly spotted Glimmer and Bow at a nearby table, eating some breakfast.

“Hey guys,” Bow greeted brightly, “I messaged my dads last night to see if they knew anything from their studies about animals affected by First Ones’ tech, and they said they had a few texts for us to check out.”

Adora, rapidly chewing pastries, was intrigued by this lead, “That’s great, Bow.” She said between bites as she turned to Glimmer, “Can you teleport us over to the Library after breakfast?”

“I don’t know, Adora,” Catra’s voice cut in unexpectedly. “Is that a good idea right now?”

“I’m the only one who can read those texts. We need to know what we are dealing with here,” Adora insisted.

“Fine, but don’t push yourself too hard,” Catra agreed with some resignation.

Pink sparks fizzled out as they teleported into the center of the library. Bow's dads stood before them, Lance, who was tall with long dreadlocks and George with his familiar mustache.

“Hello again, Bow’s dads, Sirs,” Adora greeted a bit awkwardly and then added, “Thanks for pulling out these texts for us.” She glanced at the scrolls laid out on the table and quickly knelt down and reached for the closest one.

“Oh, hello, Adora. It was no trouble at all,” Lance greeted kindly.

As Adora began to scan through the text on the scroll, she heard Bow and Glimmer exchanging additional pleasantries and catching up with Bow’s dads in the background, but she was too focused on her task at hand to make out much of their conversation. She also heard Catra sinking onto a couch nearby her.

The first scroll she scanned was just a listing of the different types of animals on Etheria, like a species log. She quickly set that one aside and reached for another. Her hand visibly shook as she lifted it towards her.

This one was old, torn and faded. It seemed to be observational notes from a scientific record of some sort. As she started to try to read it, she felt the ever-present pain pulsing behind her eyes, and she shut them for a moment and furrowed her brow as she tried to push away the sensation and concentrate once more.

The description of an animal caught her attention. “Guys, I think I found something,” Adora called out, and the others quickly gathered around her.

"Listen to this, 'after exposure, the fox has shown signs of distress with increasing disorientation and visible shaking.' The text is too worn to make out after that, but there is one more bit here. 'We couldn't keep the animals caged. They've become too aggressive. We need to find another way to draw out their magic."

"Whoa," Bow said, taking it in. "That sounds just like what we've been seeing with the animals now."

Glimmer crossed her arms, "First Ones tech inflicted this on them? That's horrible." Her voice sharpened with her rising distress, "We need to find and shut this tech down now before this gets any worse."

Catra's tail flicked, and her ears lay back as she muttered, "Figures that the First Ones have left another mess for us to clean up centuries later."

George stated, "The phrasing suggests they were deliberately draining their magic. That's exploitation, plain and simple."

Beside him, Lance added, "Those poor creatures. They weren't just aggressive, they were in pain. Distress like that doesn't come from nowhere."

Adora listened to each response carefully, still trying to process what she had found. Once again, it seemed that some sort of First Ones' tech was wreaking havoc on Etheria and attempting to steal its natural magic. Would their damage never end?

Adora turned the faded text over in her hands, scrutinizing it for anything else, when she made out one more set of words. "It says 'Tyria outpost'."

George raised an eyebrow at that, "Tyria, we've seen that before. It's what the First Ones used to call the central area of the Whispering Woods."

Glimmer reacted immediately, "We need to head there now and see if we can find and destroy this tech."

Adora nodded her assent and turned to Bow's dads. "Thanks for all of your help with this."

Lance said, "Stay safe," as the shimmering pink magic transported them away once more.

As the pink teleportation sparks faded, they found themselves in a deep part of the Whispering Woods. Tall, twisting tree trunks surrounded them on all sides. Bow pulled out his Tracker Pad and scanned it for signatures, leading the way.

Adora felt an instinct to turn to She-Ra. Though after what had happened last time, she was afraid now of the results, so she quelled that urge for now. Still, she was on high alert, all of her senses attuned to the potential dangers of their situation.

They needed to try and find this tech, but Adora felt a growing anxiety about what could potentially happen to them in these woods. A tremor shook her hand, and she clenched it at her side. Right now, she wasn't sure she was enough to protect her friends and keep them safe. Her head and heart both pounded with her increasing anxiety and adrenaline.

Her foot caught on a root, and she stumbled slightly forward. A second passed, and she felt the same sensation again. A sudden jolt forward. Then again. She felt like she was replaying it. Each stumble blurring into the next until she wasn't even sure if she was moving forward at all. Unease flooded through her as she tried desperately to regain her footing.

She saw the others getting ahead of her. She blinked and found herself once more matching their stride. No one else seemed phased, but disorientation flooded her senses as she tried to calm her rising panic. Did that really just happen? Her mind was definitely playing some kind of trick on her. What was causing this? She had to do better at keeping her stress and anxieties from controlling her.

She heard Glimmer call out to her, but the words swirled incomprehensibly.

"What did you say?" Adora asked dazedly.

Her friends exchanged glances of confusion as none of them had spoken.

"Adora?" Glimmer asked carefully.

Adora shook her head, her breathing becoming erratic, her voice hesitant and fearful, "I-I just thought I heard something."

Her eyes darted around frantically, and she saw animals peering out at her from the trees. Then suddenly their eyes became human and looked at her with withering looks of betrayal.

Adora flinched back and gasped.

Catra reached for her shoulder. "There's nothing there, Adora." Her tail curled protectively around Adora's wrist, trying to steady her and offer her some comfort.

Bow stopped leading, staring down at his tracker pad, "I've lost the signal. There's some kind of increasing interference."

Her friends shared uneasy looks, and Adora could see their gazes flitting to her over and over. Her shame and panic rose within her.

Sudden anger blazed through her, and she yelled, "I know what you're all thinking. You think I'm weak. That I can't handle this."

In a panic, she tried to reach for her magic. The world tilted, and the edges of her vision blurred. She made a sudden, desperate, distressed sound. She felt like she was about to fall, and then everything went dark.

# Chapter 6

Adora felt a strange floating sensation. Then distant voices filtered in. They sounded urgent and panicked, but were muffled like they were coming from afar. She couldn't quite make out words, but she began to recognize something familiar in the desperate and high-pitched tones.

She felt the squeeze of her hand. The sharp sound of her own name being called out. The feel of soft fur against her cheek. Catra.

Adora tried to say something, but her lips wouldn't move. She managed to push open her eyes, and shapes flickered and blurred, wavering as she was unable to quite pull anything into focus. Her eyes dragged closed once more.

"…strong tech signal…"

She made out the words but couldn't quite make sense of them. Still, her chest tightened a bit with a feeling that she had done something wrong.

"…it's okay…"

Someone was trying to reassure her. More sensations flooded through her as she felt her aching muscles all trembling. She tried to move and felt the soft arms around her tighten as they tried to keep her steady.

Her eyes fluttered open again, and she saw wide blue and gold eyes staring with fear. Adora hated to be the cause of Catra's clear distress, and she desperately wanted to comfort her. "M'fine," she managed to say, though it came out quite slurred, likely not having the comforting effect she was after.

Catra's face blurred out again, and Glimmer and Bow blurred in for a moment, exchanging a clear look of concern. They were all

so worried about her. Adora trembled harder. She felt Catra's tail press around her waist, and it felt comforting and grounding.

The frantic pleading voices swirled around her once more as she tried to push to focus on their words again. She felt the soft press of Catra's forehead against her own, and it stabilized her a bit. The world came back into crispness once more. Her eyes focused on Catra's face more fully.

"There you are," Catra said with open relief. "You're okay now. I've got you."

Adora could feel now that she was being cradled against Catra's chest, wrapped in her arms with her head up against her shoulder. She saw that Glimmer and Bow were kneeling right nearby. The Whispering Woods surrounded them.

Adora squeezed Catra's hand. Her body continued to tremble, and she could feel a pounding in her head, but she pushed past those sensations to regain more and more awareness. Glimmer had leaned in and pressed a hand to her shoulder, and Bow continued to hover nearby.

"What happened?" Adora asked, her words more fully formed this time.

"It seemed like you were afraid of something, and then you just collapsed," Catra replied softly, her concern still clear in her expression.

Adora nodded as she tried to remember. It began to come back to her. They were in the Woods trying to find the First Ones' tech that had affected the animals. They had gotten a lead at the Library.

Increased beeping from Bow's tracker pad caught her attention. They had been trying to follow its signal to the tech.

"Are we at the tech?" Adora asked, gesturing to the noisy tracker pad.

"Not yet," Bow replied and then, trying to speak steadily though worry clearly laced through his voice, he added, "Adora, this tech signal is coming from you. The tracker pad is showing the same increased tech signatures and decreased magic as we saw with that fox."

Adora could see the wary looks that passed between her friends. Her own heart began to pound as she voiced aloud her realization, "So…I've been infected by the tech too."

Their faces confirmed her thoughts; they had obviously realized this while she had been unconscious. Her chest tightened with fear. This certainly wasn't the first time she had been affected by First Ones' tech, but that wasn't very reassuring. Her prior encounters with their data disk, the signal at Beast Island, and at the Heart had all been rather distressing, and this time it didn't seem like it was going to be better.

"Does it feel like when your sword was corrupted by that disk?" Glimmer asked, obviously thinking similar thoughts to Adora.

Adora quickly shook her head, "No, it's not like that. When that affected me, it was like I was suddenly rewired and not in control at all. This feels different." She paused for a moment, trying to figure out how to explain it. "This is much softer, but like it's messing more with my emotions and my senses."

Bow asked, "Like the signal at Beast Island?"

"Maybe a little, I don't hear a noise, and it's a different type of effect. That felt like succumbing to depression or despair. This time it's making me feel shaky, skittish…" She hesitated for a moment and added softly, "But sometimes angry too."

More worried glances were being exchanged.
Then Catra said with quiet forcefulness, "Doesn't matter how it feels. We'll deal with it." She gave Adora a reassuring squeeze.

Adora nodded, trying to feel as resolute. It wasn't really working. Sure, they were actively trying to find and destroy the tech, but

could she keep herself in control until they did so? She was supposed to be their strength, their protector, but right now she was worried that she might become the danger. Her head pounded, and her body shook. She wanted to just curl deeper into Catra's arms and stay there forever, but what good would that do? They needed to find the tech and put a stop to this now.

Adora pushed herself up, standing even if a bit shakily. Catra kept a hand on her shoulder to stabilize her. "Okay, let's do this." She turned toward Bow, "Can you still trace the other signal?"

Bow nodded and made a few motions on his tracker pad, "Yeah, the interference from before has faded, and I am getting readings of strong First Ones tech nearby."

Adora nodded and, with a determination she didn't fully feel she said, "Then lead the way."

They continued to move deeper into the Woods. Adora noticed that the shadows were dense, and she felt a strange hum beneath the air. Her thoughts swirled with her anxieties and doubts. She needed to hold it together, but she wasn't sure that she could. Her head pounded incessantly, and she felt her whole body tremble again. Catra squeezed her shoulder and let her tail wrap around Adora's wrist. Adora tried to take comfort in her strength, but it wasn't enough.

Adora began to hear odd whispers threading through the trees and a light static sound in her ears. She caught glimpses of hostile eyes in the underbrush. She felt flighty and dazed. She needed to hold it together, but fear of things getting worse threatened to overwhelm her. The disorientation was one thing, but what Adora was really afraid of was that it would lead to the return of the anger and aggression.

She was lost in her own distress and hadn't noticed that Bow and Glimmer had stopped until she nearly ran into them. She looked up suddenly to see a massive tree before them that was leafless and dying.

Embedded deep in a tangle of roots that stuck up from the ground was a large crystal. It had blackened, and First Ones' language wound across its surface, pulsing and glowing. It looked like it had once been part of some sort of shrine intentionally placed there by someone to try and heal the tree. Now, though, it had latched onto the life force of the tree and embedded itself with vines so that it was deeply secured within the roots. It was active, dangerous, and it did not look like it would be easily destroyed.

# Chapter 7

Adora stared with a mix of awe and fear at the pulsating crystal that now stood right before her, so close that it was within her reach. For days now, it had been exerting its control over both her and the animals of Etheria, making them disoriented and aggressive. It felt truly surreal to be standing before it now, this source of so much distress.

"Don't touch it," Adora shouted frantically, throwing herself between her friends and the malevolent crystal. A wave of fear and aggression filled her completely. Her eyes were darting about frantically.

"We won't, Adora," Glimmer affirmed resolutely, trying to reassure and calm her friend.

"How do we destroy it?" Bow asked hesitantly from behind her.

Adora didn't hear if any of her friends answered as her own racing thoughts now distracted her totally. It seemed clear to Adora that they would need something quite powerful to destroy it, and most likely the only viable option was She-Ra's sword. But how was she going to accomplish that right now? The truth hung heavy for her. Anxiety coursing through her at this impossible inevitability.

Her heart seized, recalling how she had collapsed just trying to even reach for her magic a mere hour ago. Her hand still instinctively rose and twitched like she would try to summon it anyway, but then she quickly curled her hand into a fist as her anxiety and fear of failure threatened to overwhelm her. Insuppressible panic rolled through her, making her pulse race and her hands shake.

The floor tilted away for a heartbeat, and she staggered. Static-like sounds filled her ears with words like "never enough" and "failure" breaking through. Adora's head pounded and her whole

body trembled uncontrollably. She felt terribly disorientated and her eyes were becoming hazy and unfocused.

Then she felt Catra's arm drape carefully around her shoulders, steadying her through each tremor. She was likely stating reassurances to Adora, but right now Adora couldn't hear a word of them. Instead, dozens of phantom voices whispered around and through her, telling her that she was weak and unworthy. Adora winced and pressed a hand to her temple, trying to push through the pain and disorientation.

Then a sudden wave of anger and aggression surged through her, and she turned and snarled unexpectedly at her friends.

"Stay back," she yelled fiercely, though her voice cracked on the last syllable as an overwhelming sense of panic coursed through her at the thought of striking her friends in her anger.

Catra released her suddenly and jumped back. Adora could feel Catra's searching eyes raking over her in fear and confusion. She knew they were all looking at her with clear distress. She saw as they furrowed their brows and threw small glances at one another. Adora wanted to say something reassuring to apologize and let them know she didn't mean to scare them, but she could not. She felt lost in waves of disorientation and surges of rolling anger. She scrunched her eyes closed and held her head in both hands as she desperately sought for control.

Then, Catra's voice cut through, soft but determined, "Adora, look at me."

Adora felt instantly grounded by that familiar raspy voice, and her eyes snapped up as she stared into those beautiful mismatched eyes. Catra's presence anchored her to reality and instantly pulled her back from her spiraling fears and fluctuating emotions.

"Even when you shake, even when you're scared, I still trust you," Catra said with a deep sincerity as she reached toward her with open arms.

Adora sank into those waiting arms. Her whole body shook as she pressed her now tear-stained face into the crook of Catra's neck. Adora took comfort from Catra's steady embrace as she tried desperately to rein in her emotions and fears and gain more control.

Adora took in a deep, stabilizing breath. She acknowledged her anxieties but resolved herself to face them. She could do this. She could be anxious and afraid and still show up. She reached inside herself to draw forth what still remained of She-Ra's draining magic.

A wave of sudden lightheadedness threatened to overwhelm her. Everything around her felt distant, like she had been pulled underwater. She staggered to her knees, still feeling Catra's hands gripping her shoulders steadily.

From afar, she heard Catra exclaim, "Adora! I hear your heart racing. Are you okay?"

Adora tried to breathe through the sensations that threatened to overwhelm her. She felt herself on the verge of losing consciousness, the edges of her vision beginning to blacken and blur. With everything in her, she forced herself to stay alert and pulled once more from within.

A transformation didn't come, but her sword flickered into her hand in a soft glow of light. Feeling the anchoring of a tail around her waist, Adora barely held onto consciousness. Trembling and on her knees, Adora managed to raise her sword, and she slammed it quickly down into the center of the crystal.

With a brilliant burst of light, it shattered. Golden swirls of the absorbed magic of Etheria released from within it, swirling outward. Glowing whisps of gold absorbed into her and the ground and drifted out toward the other affected animals of Etheria.

She had done it, really and truly done it. Despite her anxieties and her fading magic, she had pulled forth enough power to destroy this last bit of First Ones' control. And now she felt suddenly restored. She could feel her magic whole and available within her once more. Her disorientation faded, and her tremors stilled.

Then Catra, Glimmer, and Bow were surrounding and hugging her.

"I…I did it. It's gone. I can feel it's really gone." Adora exclaimed her disbelief cementing into certainty.

Glimmer gave her arm a squeeze and, with relief, said, "You had us scared for a second there, but I knew you'd find your strength. You always do."

Bow added enthusiastically, "Yeah, you destroyed the crystal and saved all of those poor animals. That's huge, Adora. You did amazing!"

Adora nodded and spoke softly, still taking it all in, "I thought I was going to lose my magic or maybe even myself, but it's all here again, and I feel whole. I feel like me."

"Took you long enough," Catra smirked, though her voice shook with her relief. Catra then reached out and stroked Adora's cheek tenderly, "I don't care about the magic. I'm just glad you're still you."

Glimmer smiled and gave another squeeze and said, "Group hug time, don't even try to fight it."

Adora just let herself lean into the strength and comfort of her friends for a few moments. Relief surged through her as the reality that this was over now began to truly settle in and fill her with renewed warmth.

That evening, back at Bright Moon, Adora met up with General Juliet for a debrief.

"All the patrols have checked in, Commander. The borders are quiet. There have been no more erratic animal sightings or disturbances. The villagers are saying that the Woods feel safe again," Juliet reported and then added, "Leadership isn't proven when everything runs smoothly. It's proven in the choices made in the uncertainty. Bright Moon can rest easy tonight thanks to you."

Adora smiled softly, "Thank you, General. I don't always feel like I'm making the right choices, but I really appreciate that."

Exhaustion from the day setting in, Adora walked back toward her room. She really hoped that she would always be able to do enough for the guards, the villagers of Bright Moon, and all of Etheria. She always tried to do what she could, but she still wasn't sure that was always enough. She realized she was spiraling into her own self-doubt again, but she acknowledged that at least now they were just thoughts and she no longer had the pounding headache and tremors from before, which was certainly a relief.

Stepping into her room, Melog came right up and curled around her legs, and Adora gave it a few soft pats. Her eyes immediately drifted to Catra, and she gave her a tired smile.

"Hey, Adora," Catra greeted her softly. "Melog is glad that you're okay now. They were worried." She reached for her hand and added, "I was pretty worried too. I'm really glad that you're back to being you."

Adora returned the squeeze and said, "Yeah, it's nice to feel more like me again. I mean, I still have some anxieties and doubts, but I've realized that's okay just as long as I still show up."

A tap on the balcony window made Adora look up to see Swift Wind. She stepped outside and gave her favorite steed's neck a pat. "Hey, Swifty, I'm sure you've been sensing a lot of distress today, but it's okay. I'm okay now."

"That's a relief, Adora. You know Etheria doesn't need you to be flawless, just you doing your best."

“Thanks, Swifty, I think I get that now.” She smiled and gave his neck a tight hug. “Have a good sleep,” she said as she stepped back inside.

The next morning, Adora attended her usual breakfast meeting with the senior guards, and they confirmed that everything had held stable through the night. Adora then met up with Catra, and they walked to the Whispering Woods. Entering the Woods once more, Adora felt a bit nervous but also resolute. She knew now that, despite her ever-present doubts and anxieties, she was ready for whatever would come next.

Adora reached out to touch the trees, and she felt the hum of Etheria’s magic whispering back comfortingly. There were no more static threats or preying eyes. The animals were all docile and content once more, having resumed their normal routines. Adora caught a glimpse of an Etherian wolf with its light green fur and six pearly blue eyes, caring for its pups deep between the trees. She heard the pleasant cadence of birdsong filling the air. Catra’s hand slipped into hers and gave a soft squeeze, and Adora felt comforted by the wonder of the Whispering Woods once more.

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